country and restricting the political rights of those already there. The Punjabi community, especially the Sikhs, had hitherto been a loyal force of the British empire , and they naturally expected equal treatment and rights from the British and Commonwealth governments as extended to British and other white immigrants.

'The continuous passage' (reaching Canada without break of journey from place of origin) law and other discriminatory measures restricting immigration of south Asians to Canada led to discontent, protests, and anti-colonial and nationalistic sentiments within the Sikh community. As a result, it began organizing itself into political groups. It was during this period that Tarak Nath Das published an edition of *Free Hindustan* from Vancouver, which provoked a reaction from the British government when it was published in India. [2]

In 1907, the Khalsa Diwan Society was set up in Vancouver. Though its objectives were religious, educational and philanthropic, it also took note of problems connected to immigration and racism. The Gursikh temple at 1866, Second Avenue, West Vancouver, was established on 26 February 1911. Sikhs and non-Sikhs from British Columbia attended the ceremony, and a local newspaper reported on the event. It was the first gurudwara not only in North America but in the world outside south Asia. Soon the gurudwara management wing of the Khalsa Diwan Society built some other gurudwaras in Vancouver, Victoria, Surrey and neighbouring areas, which became centres of Sikh socio-religious and political activities. The Sikh population in British Columbia and the west coast of the US, however, got depleted during the Ghadar movement, when thousands of Sikhs sold their properties and moved back to India to participate in the freedom movement against the British.

The door to Canada was firmly shut against the Sikhs by the Canadian government in 1908. A small community of Sikh workers had been established in the Pacific coast states of the US and in the British Columbia by 1910. During the period 1919–47, generally referred to as 'quiet years' in the Canadian Sikh history, the Sikh population dwindled in size. It is hard to tell how many Sikhs left British Columbia during these quiet years. Some shifted southwards to the US and others returned to Punjab. The population dropped